

HINDUSTAN TIMES

PRALHAD JOSHI, *61* | BJP
Minister of New & Renewable Energy

Rousing start Joshi's political career took off with the communal troubles and the flag-hoisting events at Idgah Maidan in Hubli during the early 1990s, which led to his election as the president of the BJP's Dharwad district unit. Subsequently, he also headed the party in the state

Inside man A five-time MP from Dharwad, Joshi is valued for his organisational and election management skills. A trusted aide of the Modi-Shah duo, Joshi had been propped up as a national leader from Karnataka after Ananth Kumar's death. The mild-mannered Joshi has friends across party lines. He's also not seen as a threat by the two major BJP groups in the state, one led by ex-CM B.S. Yediyurappa and the other owing allegiance to B.L.

BREAKING THE GRID LOCK

Joshi's big challenge, apart from synergies with the power ministry, will be to popularise the green fuels of the future

By ANILESH S. MAHAJAN

India has set an ambitious target of 500 gigawatts of renewable energy capacities by 2030–31, along with developing affordable storage capacities and the National Green Hydrogen Mission, which plans to produce 5 MT of green hydrogen annually by then. This is in addition to the PM Surya Ghar Muft Bijli Yojana, which aims to provide 300 units of free electricity every month to 10 million households. Prime Minister Narendra Modi has said at various events that India will have to scale this up three-fold but this will be impossible if both power ministries do not work in tandem. In the past decade, India's renewables story became a success as the power sector (transmission companies) allowed free access to green corridors, DISCOMs were asked to buy electricity from renewables on priority and local dispatch centres of transmission infrastructure was asked to never back out on renewables. Joshi's biggest challenge will be to continue with these synergies with 'minimum transition loss'. ■

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

POWER TO THE POOR The PM Surya Ghar Muft Bijli Yojana was aimed at providing 300 units of free electricity monthly via rooftop solar units to 10 million poor households. Modi has now set a new target–30 million households. An outlay of Rs 75,000 crore has been approved for this

POLICY ISSUES Solar module prices have dropped substantially worldwide in recent years, but in India, of late, they have had to bear the brunt of fluctuating import tax policies–the government first imposed high